

## MODULE 17 / 40

# American Crow

*Corvus brachyrhynchos***QUICK STATS**

|          |                                   |
|----------|-----------------------------------|
| Length   | 17.5 – 21.0 in (44 – 53 cm)       |
| Wingspan | 33.5 – 39.4 in (85 – 100 cm)      |
| Weight   | 11.2 – 21.9 oz (316 – 620 g)      |
| Lifespan | Up to 16 years (avg. 7–8 in wild) |

**PRESENTATION**

The American Crow is one of the most intelligent, adaptable, and ecologically important birds in North America — a large, all-black bird with a heavy bill, fan-shaped tail, and an extraordinary capacity for learning, problem-solving, and social organization. Crows can recognize individual human faces, use tools, pass information between generations, and hold "funerals" for fallen flock members — behaviors once thought exclusive to primates. Their loud, familiar "caw" is one of the most iconic sounds of the North American landscape. Highly social and opportunistic, they thrive in virtually every habitat from wilderness to city centers.

**HABITAT & RANGE**

The American Crow is found year-round across most of North America, from southern Canada through the entire contiguous United States except for the driest desert regions. It occupies an extraordinary range of habitats: farmland, forest edges, river valleys, coastal shorelines, suburban neighborhoods, parks, and city centers. It is one of the few species that has benefited from human landscape changes, thriving wherever there is a mix of open foraging areas and trees for roosting and nesting. Northern populations move south in winter, often forming massive communal roosts of thousands to hundreds of thousands of birds.

**DIET & FEEDING**

- Virtually omnivorous — one of the broadest diets of any bird
- Grain, corn, and seeds scavenged from fields and feeders
- Insects, earthworms, and small mammals
- Carrion and roadkill — an important ecological scavenger
- Eggs and nestlings of other birds
- Fruit, berries, nuts, and human food scraps

BEHAVIOR & SOCIAL LIFE

American Crows are among the most socially complex birds in the world. They live in extended family groups where offspring from previous years help their parents raise subsequent broods — a behavior called cooperative breeding. Family groups maintain tight bonds year-round, foraging together, mobbing predators collectively, and communicating with a rich vocabulary of calls. Crows can recognize and remember individual human faces for years, and will "hold grudges" against people who have threatened them while tolerating those who have been kind. In winter, unrelated crows gather in communal roosts that can number in the millions, providing warmth and safety in numbers.

NESTING & BREEDING

Crows nest in late winter and early spring, building large, bulky cup nests of sticks lined with bark strips, grass, and soft material in the crotch of a tall tree. Clutches of 3–6 pale green or blue-gray eggs with brown spots are incubated by the female for 17–19 days. Both parents and often "helper" offspring from previous years feed the nestlings. Young fledge at 28–35 days but remain with the family group for 1–5 years. Breeding pairs mate for life.

SONG & COMMUNICATION

The American Crow has one of the most complex vocal repertoires of any North American bird — researchers have identified over 20 distinct call types. The familiar "caw" varies in pitch, repetition, and rhythm to convey different messages: alarm, aggression, assembly, and contact. Crows also produce a remarkable array of rattles, coos, clicks, and mimicked sounds. Family members recognize each other's voices individually.

CONSERVATION STATUS

|                |               |                   |        |
|----------------|---------------|-------------------|--------|
| IUCN Red List: | Least Concern | Population trend: | Stable |
|----------------|---------------|-------------------|--------|

The American Crow population is estimated at 27 million individuals and is broadly stable. It suffered dramatic declines during the initial spread of West Nile Virus in the early 2000s — crows are among the most susceptible species — but has largely recovered in most areas. It remains one of the most abundant and visible large birds in North America.

FEEDER TIPS

- Crows rarely use traditional feeders — offer food on the ground or a large platform
- Whole corn, peanuts in shell, and kitchen scraps attract them reliably
- They are wary — place food in an open area where they can watch for danger
- Crows remember generous feeding spots and return reliably for years
- Avoid feeding near songbird feeders — crows can intimidate smaller birds

COLORING GUIDE

| ZONE             | RECOMMENDED COLOR                      |
|------------------|----------------------------------------|
| Entire body      | <i>Jet black — uniform and glossy</i>  |
| Iridescence      | <i>Blue-violet sheen in sunlight</i>   |
| Bill             | <i>Heavy, curved, black</i>            |
| Legs & feet      | <i>Black</i>                           |
| Eye              | <i>Dark brown — appears black</i>      |
| Juvenile plumage | <i>Duller black; blue eye at first</i> |

## COLOR ME!

American Crow • *Corvus brachyrhynchos* • Module 17

